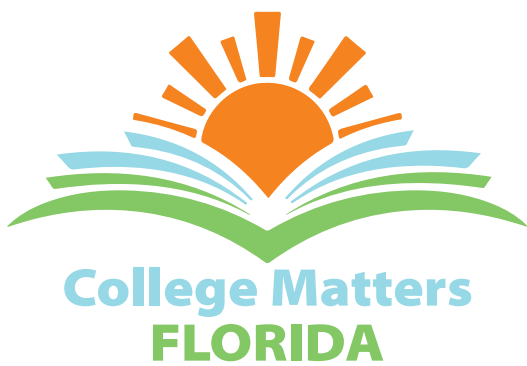




PROMISING PRACTICES

NUMBER 3

Promoting Individualized Education Plan Goals and Activities for Students with Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities in the Transition to Postsecondary Education

Program Background

As opportunities to attend college increase for students with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD), we must develop individualized education plan (IEP) goals that prepare students for these college opportunities. Secondary level transition specialists, special education teachers, and others involved in the IEP goal development and writing processes are now in a position to inform IEP teams about the experiences students with IDD might have at college. These staff can share how to include benchmarks and activities in students' education and transition services that can prepare them for postsecondary education success. Ideally, schools will implement these IEPs in the least restrictive settings and promote a philosophy of full inclusion for students.

Implementation

Karla Wade is a retired transition coordinator for a large metropolitan city. She was excited to create examples that would highlight emerging opportunities for students with IDD to access inclusive postsecondary education. Karla became aware of the new initiative while attending a meeting at Kennesaw State University, which was developing the first inclusive college program in Georgia. As a long-term transition specialist, Karla recognizes the significant impact inclusive postsecondary education experiences can have on students and K-12 education systems. She understands that a student's IEP is a starting point where teams can design postsecondary vision, transition assessments, goals, benchmarks, and objectives to broaden student planning to include college. Karla decided to develop transition-focused IEP goals that included sample goals reflecting college preparation.

After preparing draft goals, Karla sought feedback. She shared the draft with a respected colleague at Kennesaw State's college program. Karla's colleague advised her to focus on the independent skills students need to achieve college success rather than solely on academic achievement.

As a result of this work, Karla drafted a wide array of IEP goals and activities in six critical domain areas. The domain areas are:

1. Education/Training
2. Development of Employment
3. Community Participation
4. Adult Living/Post-School Options
5. Related Services
6. Daily Living Skills

Examples of a goal and activity within two selected domains are:

- Domain: Education/Training
 - » Goal: Develop (add #) ideas about a topic for the purpose of speaking to a group per (week, month, or semester)
 - » Activity: Presents (add #) ideas verbally per (week, month, or semester)



This project is provided by the Florida Developmental Disabilities Council, Inc., supported in part by grant numbers 1901FLSCDD-01 and 2001FLSCDD-01 from the U.S. Administration for Community Living, Department of Health and Human Services, Washington, D.C. 20201. Grantees undertaking projects with government sponsorship are encouraged to express freely their findings and conclusions. Points of view or opinions do not, therefore, necessarily represent official ACL policy.

- Domain: Development of Employment
 - » Goal: Holds a part-time job or volunteer position
 - » Activity: Practice interview skills (add #) times per (week, month, or semester)

All domains are important to successful college entry and completion, however, each student will have areas of strength and need within each domain. First, teams can use assessment data, student interaction, and family engagement to determine which domain areas to highlight in the IEP and which domains and goals to address. Another effective planning method is to begin with college entry in mind and set up appropriate IEP goals with the intent of building upon skills across middle and high school. College entry and success is a work in progress for all potential students.

Impact

Since disseminating the IEP goal examples to prepare students with IDD for college, Karla has received numerous requests across the country from school and transition staff who want to use the examples as a reference to prepare IEPs for high school students with IDD. They also want to share the examples with their colleagues and with families who want to develop similar IEPs.

Having a set of possible transition goals and activities for students interested in inclusive postsecondary education can result in several important outcomes. First, students and families are aware of inclusive postsecondary education as a potential next step in the student's educational experience. Moreover, they are aware of a series of skill domains with optional goals and activities that can be part of the transition IEP. In this regard, students and families are able to more effectively advocate for individualized and appropriate adult life goals. Next, school professionals are more aware of, and likely better positioned to, suggest IEP goals and activities focused on the continuation of the education for students with IDD. Lastly, data clearly demonstrates the profound positive impact postsecondary education has on students with IDD. Students have reported significantly improved rates of competitive integrated employment, work earnings, and quality of life following participation in inclusive postsecondary education.

Suggestions for Replication

- Make school professionals, students, and families aware of inclusive postsecondary education opportunities.
- Use school events, including open houses and school fairs, to promote college opportunities for students.
- Share examples of IEP goals and activities that promote skills and strategies for college entry and completion with students and families. Share these examples well in advance of IEP meetings.
- Use the example domain goals and activities from this document to develop unique individualized IEP goals and activities for students.
- Be sure that documents with IEP examples are editable; we are always learning about new skills that students with IDD need in college.
- Continue to have high expectations for students with IDD and use sample IEP goals that reflect these high expectations.

Additional Resources

- Boyle, A., (2018). Documenting Student Growth in Inclusive Dual Enrollment Experiences, Think College Grab and Go Practices, Number 5. Institute for Community Inclusion, University of Massachusetts Boston.
- Boyle, A. (2018). Inclusive Dual Enrollment Student Evaluation Tool. Boston, MA: University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.
- Hart, D., Boyle, M., & Jones, M. (2017). The Foundational Skills for the College and Career Learning Plan (CCLP). Boston, MA: University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.
- Wade, K. (2014). Transition IEP goals and activities to prepare for inclusive postsecondary education. Think College Resource Library. Boston, MA: University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.

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